Say It Three Times

THE ALPHABET PSALMS, AND HOW TO WRITE ONE



Nine psalms in the Bible are built on the alphabet, from A all the way to Z. Six of them have letters missing, and nobody ever went back and fixed them. This is a book about why anybody would write that way — and how to write one yourself.

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Say It Three Times

> *The alphabet psalms, and how to write one · for teenagers*

BEFORE YOU START

A psalm is a song.

Not a poem somebody wrote down for you to read quietly on your own. A song — with a tune, sung out loud, usually with other people, often with instruments and sometimes with drums. We have lost all the tunes. We only have the words.

There are a hundred and fifty of them in the Bible, collected together in a book called Psalms. They were written over hundreds of years by a lot of different people. King David wrote many of them. He did not write all of them, and some of them were written by people whose names nobody knows any more.

They say everything. Some are happy. Some are thank-yous. Some are furious. Some were written by somebody who was certain God had walked off and left them, and who said so. Nobody took those ones out for being too much.

This book is about nine of them, and about one other part of the Bible that was built the same way.

1

THE PSALM WITH A LETTER MISSING

There is one psalm that an old Jewish teaching tells you to say three times every day.

People still do. Morning, and again later in the morning, and once in the afternoon. They have been doing it for a very long time – longer than there have been cars, or books you could buy, or most of the countries on a map.

It is Psalm 145.

Most people have never heard of it.

Here it is. Read it slowly, and out loud if you can, because that is what it was made for.

> **A** – Always I will lift you high, my God and King. I will bless your name, and not stop.
>
> **B** – Blessing you is what I will do every single day, for as long as there is a me.
>
> **C** – Count his greatness if you like. Nobody has ever reached the bottom of it.
>
> **D** – Down the years one lot of people tells the next what you have done.

E – Every beautiful thing about you, I turn over in my mind, slowly.

F – Frightening things you have done, and people still talk about them. I will too.

G – Goodness pours out of you, and people cannot help singing about it.

H – Hesed is what you are full of. Kind. Patient. Slow to get angry.

I – It is not only for some. You are good to everyone, and your kindness covers everything you ever made.

J – Just look: everything you made is saying thank you, and the people you have loved are blessing you.

K – Kingdom – they will talk about yours, and about how strong you are.

L – Letting everybody know, so that nobody misses it.

M – My God, your kingdom has no end date. It keeps going through every generation.

N – ⟨ ⟩

O – On anyone who is falling, you keep hold. Anyone bent double, you straighten up.

P – Patient eyes look up at you, and you give them their food at the right time.

R – Reaching out, you open your hand, and every living thing gets what it needs.

> **S** – Straight and fair in everything you do. Kind in everything you make.
>
> **T** – To anyone who calls you – really calls – you are already close.
>
> **U** – Up go their cries, and you hear them, and you come.
>
> **V** – Very carefully you keep everyone who loves you. The ones who choose cruelty will not last.
>
> **W** – With my own mouth I will say it. And let everything that breathes bless your holy name, for ever.

Did you notice anything?

Go back and look at the first letter of each line.

The psalm was written in Hebrew, which has twenty-two letters, and it runs through all of them in order. A, B, C, and on to the end. I have used our alphabet here so you can see what the first readers saw. Your Bible will say it differently, because it is translating the words rather than the letters, and you cannot usually do both at once.

There are eight more like this in the book of Psalms, and one more somewhere else. This book is about all of them.

Why would anybody write a poem that way?

You might think: to help people remember it. That is what nearly everybody says. But it is probably not the main reason, and we will see why in a few chapters' time.

Here is the better answer. If you go from A to Z, you have not left anything out.

The old rabbis actually argued about this, and they asked the same question we just did — why *this* psalm, three times a day?

One of them said: because of the alphabet.

Somebody pointed out that there is a psalm that does the alphabet far harder than this one. Psalm 119 is the longest chapter in the Bible. It has eight lines in a row starting with A, then eight starting with B, then eight starting with C, all the way through. One hundred and seventy-six lines. If the alphabet were the reason, that one ought to win.

So another of them said: because of the line at R.

Go back and read it. *Reaching out, you open your hand, and every living thing gets what it needs.* You open your hand when you are giving something away — it is what you do to hand somebody food. The psalm has God doing that for everything alive at once. Every person. Every animal. Every bird on the fence.

Somebody pointed out that there is a different psalm that says the same thing.

The answer they settled on was that this psalm has both. The whole alphabet, *and* the open hand. Everything said, about a God who leaves nobody out.

One word to carry with you

Look at line H.

Hesed is a Hebrew word, and English has no single word for it. People usually translate it “steadfast love”, which is a mouthful and does not help much.

Here is the closer idea. **Hesed is love that comes from a decision, not from a feeling.**

Feelings move about. Somebody is warm with you on Tuesday and cool with you on Friday, and you spend a good deal of energy working out which one you are getting today.

Hesed does not work like that. It made a decision about you, and now it acts on the decision. On the good days. On the bad days. On the days when you have been awful and you know it. It does not stop first to check how it feels about you.

That word is in this psalm once. Only once, at line H. And then it does something.

Watch where it goes

After line H, the psalm stops talking about hesed and starts showing it.

Anyone falling gets held. Anyone bent double gets straightened. Every pair of eyes gets fed. The hand opens and everything alive gets what it needs. Anyone who calls finds him already close.

Now go back through and count how many times you can find the word **all**, or **every**, or **everyone**. Do it before you read the next sentence.

In the Hebrew it is there seventeen times. That is more than any other psalm its size. All who fall. All who are bent. The eyes of all. Every living thing. All his ways. All his works. All who call. All who love him.

A to Z. Nothing left out, and nobody.

Now — the bracket

You will have seen it. There is a letter missing.

In Hebrew the missing letter is called *nun*, and it comes between M and O. The psalm goes straight from one to the other, and there is no line for it. Nobody has ever found a copy that explains why.

Some very old copies do have a line there: *God is faithful in his words, and kind in all he does.* Other copies do not. People have been arguing about whether it was lost or whether it was never there for more than fifteen hundred years. Nobody knows.

But here is what one of those old rabbis said, and it is worth hearing.

In Hebrew, he said, the word for *fallen* starts with that letter. There is a line in the prophet Amos that begins with it: *Fallen, and not getting up again, is Israel.* So maybe, he said, David did not want that letter in a song about God. Maybe he left it out on purpose.

And another one said: look at what comes next.

The very next line — the one at O, where the alphabet picks up again — says this.

On anyone who is falling, you keep hold.

That is their reading, not a fact. But it is a good one. The letter for falling goes missing, and the next thing the psalm says is that nobody who falls gets dropped.

Keep the bracket in mind. It happens again.

BEFORE THE NEXT CHAPTER

Three letters. That is all.

First, the thing to know. Psalm 145 is mostly said **to God** — to him, as if he were standing there. That is what you are doing too.

Pick three letters. The letters of your name, or three that spell a word, or three you just like the look of. It does not matter which.

Now write one line for each, said to God, beginning with that letter.

Here is one person's first go, using G, O and D:

> **G** — God, you are stronger than anything I am scared of.
>
> **O** — Only you have never once let me down.
>
> **D** — Do I trust you? I want to.

Look at the last one. It is a question, and he left it as a question. That is allowed. Some of the psalms in this book are nothing but questions.

Three rules:

1. Say it out loud before you write it down. This is a song, not an essay.
2. It does not have to be good.
3. If one of them will not come, put a bracket. You are allowed. The psalm did.

2

THE TWINS

Turn two pages of the Bible and you find two poems sitting next to each other that are exactly the same size.

Both start with the same shout — *Hallelujah*, which just means "praise the LORD". Both run the whole alphabet, A to Z, in order. Both have twenty-two lines to do it in.

And this time there is no bracket. Nothing is missing from either of them. Out of all the alphabet psalms in this book, only these two and one other get all the way through without a gap.

They are Psalm 111 and Psalm 112, and once you notice what they are doing you cannot unsee it.

Psalm 111 is about God.

What he is like. What he has done. That he keeps his promises, that he feeds people, that he is fair, that he does not change his mind about his own family.

Psalm 112 is about a person.

Not a famous person. Just somebody God has been working on.

Now look at what they share

This is the part worth slowing down for. The two poems use the *same words*. Not similar words. The same ones.

PSALM 111, ABOUT GOD	PSALM 112, ABOUT THE PERSON
His doing-right **lasts forever**	His doing-right **lasts forever** — word for word the same line
He **gives** food to people who respect him	He **gives**, scattering it about, to anyone poor
His instructions are **held up** solid	His heart is **held up** solid
He made sure his wonders would be **remembered**	He will be **remembered**, and for good
He does what is **fair**	He runs his affairs **fairly**

Somebody wrote a poem about God. Then they wrote a poem about a person, and used the same words.

And then the line that should not be there

In Psalm 111 there is a description of God that turns up all over the Bible. It is the oldest and best-known way of saying what he is like.

Gracious and merciful.

Two words, always about God. It is the same family of words as the line you met in chapter 1 — the *hesed* line, love that has made up its mind.

And in Psalm 112, those two words are used **about the man**.

Nobody is saying the man has become God. He has not. The claim is bigger than a compliment and smaller than that: what God is like, he makes his people like. The poem does not argue for it. It just does it, and leaves you to notice.

(There is an honest wrinkle here. The Hebrew of that line in Psalm 112 does not say who it is talking about. Most people read it as the man. Some read it as God. The poem does not tell us, and you are allowed to notice that.)

The hinge

The last line of Psalm 111 says that respecting God is where wisdom starts.

The first line of Psalm 112 says: here is somebody who respects God.

One poem finishes and the next one begins at exactly that spot, like a relay. Psalm 111 says where it starts. Psalm 112 says what it looks like afterwards.

Where they stop being the same

They do not end together.

Psalm 111's last line is about **praise that lasts forever**.

Psalm 112's last line is not about the man at all. It is about people who wanted nothing to do with any of this, and it says that what they were after is going to come to nothing.

So the poem about God ends on something that keeps going. The poem about the person ends on something that runs out.

Which is a strange way to finish — until you notice that everything belonging to the man in Psalm 112 was described, three separate times, as **lasting forever**. He got the durable words. The last line is about everybody else.

BEFORE THE NEXT CHAPTER

One letter. Two lines.

Last time you wrote three lines. This time you only need one letter — but you are going to use it twice.

Pick a letter. Any one.

Write **two** lines beginning with it:

- the first one to God, about what he is like;
- the second one about the person you would like to be.

Here is one, using K:

> **K** — Kind is what you are, even to people who are not kind back.
>
> **K** — Keeping my temper when my brother wrecks things. That is what I want.

That is all Psalms 111 and 112 are doing. One about him, one about somebody he has made like himself, in the same words.

The second line is harder than the first. That is not you getting it wrong. It is harder for everybody, and if it will not come, put a bracket there and leave it.

3

THE ONE WITH A STORY ATTACHED

Most psalms do not tell you when they were written. This one does.

There is a line above Psalm 34, before it starts, and it says this poem comes from the time David pretended to be mad in front of a king, and got thrown out, and escaped.

What happened

David was being hunted. He ran, and the only place left to run was the country of his enemies — the same people whose champion he had killed. He walked into their city and was recognised almost at once.

So he pretended to be insane. He scratched at the doors of the gate and let spit run down into his beard, until the king said *why have you brought me a madman, I have enough of those*, and had him pushed out.

That is how he got out alive. Humiliated, and alive.

And then, at some point afterwards, he sat down and wrote a poem about it in alphabetical order.

Hold on to that. The panic was not in order. The poem is. Going A to Z is not something you do while it is happening. It is what you do afterwards, when you want the whole thing said and nothing left out — including the parts you would rather skip.

Here it is. Out loud, if you can.

> **A** – Always, whatever is going on, I am going to bless God.
>
> **B** – Bragging is what I am doing – but about him, not me. People having a hard time hear it and cheer up.
>
> **C** – Come and make him big with me. Let us do it together.
>
> **D** – Desperate, I asked him for help. He answered. He got me out of every single thing I was frightened of.
>
> **E** – Everyone who looks at him lights up. Nobody who does walks away ashamed.
>
> **F** – ⟨ ⟩
>
> **G** – Got nothing, this man, and he shouted – and God heard him and pulled him out of the lot of it.
>
> **H** – Heaven's angel camps in a circle round the people who take God seriously.
>
> **I** – If you want to know whether he is good, taste him. Try it and see.
>
> **J** – Just take him seriously, all of you. People who do are not left short.
>
> **K** – Killer lions go hungry. People looking for God do not miss out on anything worth having.
>
> **L** – Listen, kids. Come here. I will teach you how to take God seriously.
>
> **M** – Many days, and a good life. Is that what you want?
>
> **N** – Nothing rotten out of your mouth, then. And no lies.

> **O** – Off with the bad things. Do good ones. Go after peace and chase it down.
>
> **P** – People doing right: his eyes are on them, and his ears are open to them.
>
> **R** – Rotten ones get the other look – the one that means they will not be remembered.
>
> **S** – Shout for help, and he hears it, and gets you out.
>
> **T** – To anybody whose heart is smashed, he is close. He saves people who have been crushed.
>
> **U** – Up against a great deal, people who do right are. He gets them through all of it.
>
> **V** – Very carefully he looks after their bones. Not one of them gets broken.
>
> **W** – What finishes cruel people in the end is their own cruelty.

Taste and see

Line I is the famous one. *If you want to know whether he is good, taste him.*

Notice what it is not. It is not an argument. David does not set out to prove anything. He has just told you he was so frightened he pretended to be mad, and that God got him out – and now he says: try it yourself.

You cannot be argued into knowing what an orange tastes like. Somebody can describe it very well and you still will not know. There is only one way to find out.

Taste it.

That is the whole of line I.

Another bracket

You will have spotted it. There is no F.

In Hebrew, the missing letter here is called *vav*. It is the sixth letter, and this poem simply does not have a line for it.

In chapter 1 the rabbis had a theory about the missing letter. There are theories about this one as well, and none of them has ever been settled.

That is two psalms in a row now with a hole in the alphabet. Start counting.

And then — one more line

The poem ends at W. That is the last letter. There is nowhere else for it to go.

And then there is another line.

> God buys his people back. Nobody who hides in him is going to be condemned.

It starts with the wrong letter. It is outside the pattern altogether, stuck on after the alphabet has run out. The poem was finished. There was one more thing.

Remember that extra line. In two chapters' time you will meet another psalm that does exactly the same thing – runs the whole alphabet, finishes, and then adds one more. The two extra lines are built on the same word.

But they are not the same sentence, and the difference between them is worth waiting for.

BEFORE THE NEXT CHAPTER

Five letters. One real thing.

So far you have written about God. This time write about something that happened.

Pick something real. A week that went badly. A scare. Something you were dreading that turned out fine. Something that did not.

Now write five lines about that one thing – A, B, C, D and E – in order.

They do not have to be sad or happy. David's poem is both at once. He tells you he was terrified and he tells you he is glad, in the same poem, about the same week.

Then, when you have finished the five, do one more thing.

Add a sixth line that starts with any letter you like. Outside the pattern. The thing you still wanted to say after you had run out of room.

One warning. You will be tempted to make it sound tidier than it actually was. Leave the ugly parts in. Going A to Z is how you get the whole thing said, and the whole thing is what you are after.

4

THE SLOW ONE

Here is a question you have probably already asked.

Why do people who cheat seem to do so well?

The one who copies gets the good mark. The one who shoves gets the ball. The one who lies about you is popular by lunchtime. Meanwhile you did the right thing and nobody noticed, and it is hard to see what the right thing bought you.

There is a psalm about exactly this. Only one psalm in this book is longer – the monster in chapter 6 – and this one is about that question and nothing else.

The first thing it does is agree with you

Psalm 37 does not tell you that you have got it wrong, or that bad people are secretly miserable, or that you only think it looks unfair.

It takes it as read. Yes. They are doing well. You are looking at it correctly.

Then it says something you will not like.

Wait.

Some of it

I cannot print this psalm here. It is forty verses long and it would take four pages.

That is worth knowing on its own. The psalm about waiting is the second-longest alphabet psalm in the Bible. It does not hurry, and it will not let you hurry either. You cannot skim an alphabet.

Here is the start of it, then some from the middle.

> **A** – Angry about people who cheat? Do not be. Do not envy them either.
>
> **B** – Believe God, and do good. Stay where he put you.
>
> **C** – Commit your road to him. Trust him. He will see to it.
>
> **D** – Do nothing, for a minute. Stand still in front of him, and wait.
>
> **E** – Ease off the anger. Put the temper down. It only ever takes you somewhere worse.

...and on it goes, two verses at a time, all the way through...

> **N** – Never once, in my whole life – and I am an old man now – have I seen God walk off and leave somebody who was doing right.
>
> **O** – Off with the bad things. Do the good ones. Then you get to stay.
>
> **P** – ⟨ ⟩
>
> **R** – Right-living people: listen to what comes out of their mouths. It is worth having.

> **S** – Spying on them, the cruel ones are, waiting for their chance.
>
> **W** – Where does rescue come from, for people doing right? From him. Nowhere else.

About that line at N

Stop there for a second, because somebody reading this will know it is not that simple.

An old man says he has never seen God abandon somebody who was doing right. And you might be able to think of a family, maybe your own, where it looks very much as though that is exactly what happened.

Notice what he actually says. Not *this never happens*. He says *I have not seen it*. It is a report of one long life, by somebody who has been watching for a long time, and he is telling you what he has got.

And the same psalm – a few lines later – takes it for granted that people doing right get hunted, spied on, and have a hard time of it. It is not pretending.

So it is not a promise that nothing bad will happen to you. It is an old man saying: I have been looking a long while, and God does not walk off.

You are allowed to find that hard. Keep reading anyway. There is a psalm coming in chapter 7 that is angrier about this than you are.

The bracket

There is no P.

In Hebrew the missing letter is called *ayin*, and it is the sixteenth. Where it should be, the line starts with a different letter altogether.

That is three psalms in a row with a hole in them. Psalm 145 had no *nun*. Psalm 34 had no *vav*. Now this.

If the alphabet was supposed to keep everything in order, it is not doing a very good job.

Keep counting.

BEFORE THE NEXT CHAPTER

One line a day. Seven days.

This chapter is about waiting, so this exercise takes a week. You cannot do it tonight.

Think of one thing that is not fair. Something real, going on now — not a made-up one, and not somebody else's.

Then, for seven days:

- **Day one**, write a line starting with A, about that thing, said to God.
- **Day two**, a line starting with B. Same thing. Say it again, differently.
- And on, to G, on day seven.

Do not write them all at once. That is the whole exercise. Something happens to a complaint when you have to pick it up again seven days running.

You may well still be angry on day seven. Say so, if you are. The psalm is not asking you to pretend. But look again at line E — it warns you that the anger itself will take you somewhere worse. That is the thing to watch.

5

THE ONE THAT ASKS

Every psalm you have met so far has been telling God he is good.

This one wants something.

It is an alphabet poem like the others, A to Z, the whole thing. But it is not a thank-you and it is not praise. Most of it is a person asking.

You can do that. That is the point of the chapter. The alphabet is not only for the good days.

> **A** – All of me, I am lifting up to you.
>
> **B** – Because I trust you, do not let me end up humiliated.
>
> **C** – Can anybody who waits for you end up ashamed? No. Not one.
>
> **D** – Direct me. Show me which way you go, and teach me to walk it.
>
> **E** – Every day I am waiting for you. Lead me in what is true.
>
> **F** – ⟨ ⟩
>
> **G** – Go back and remember your kindness. It has been going a very long time.
>
> **H** – How I was when I was young – do not remember that. Remember me the way your love remembers me.

I – If you have got it wrong, he still teaches you. That is the sort of person he is.

J – Just the ones who know they need it. They are the ones he leads.

K – Kindness and truth. Every road he takes is made out of those two.

L – Look at how much I have done wrong, and forgive it anyway, because of who you are.

M – Men and women who take him seriously get shown which way to go.

N – Nothing goes missing for them. Their children get the land.

O – On close terms. That is what God is with people who take him seriously.

P – Permanently I am watching him, because he is the one who gets my feet out of the trap.

R – Round here I am on my own and it hurts. Turn and look at me.

S – Seems to be getting bigger, the trouble inside me. Get me out of it.

T – ⟨ ⟩

U – Understand what I am carrying. And forgive the whole lot.

U – Understand how many of them there are, and how much they hate me.

V – Veer in and guard me. Get me out. I am hiding in you.

W – What keeps me is honesty and doing right. I am waiting for you.

The word from chapter 1 is back

Look at **G**, **H** and **K**.

Kindness, three times in three lines. In Hebrew that word is *hesed*, the one from line H of Psalm 145.

And look at what he does with it. At **G** he asks God to remember his hesed. At **H** he asks God to forget something about him and remember him *by* hesed instead. At **K** he says every road God walks on is built out of it.

That is somebody asking to be dealt with on the basis of what God is like rather than what he himself has been like.

Read line H again.

Now count the damage

This poem has more missing from it than any you have met.

There is no **F** – the same letter that went missing in Psalm 34.

There is no **T**.

And there are two **U**s. The letter before T is used twice to cover the gap, or not to cover it, depending on how you look.

Three psalms in a row had one hole each. This one has two holes and a repeat.

The doubled line

Go back and look at the two U lines.

In Hebrew they start with the same word, and the word means *look at this*.

Look at what I am carrying. Look at how many of them there are.

He says it twice, because he is not finished.

One more line, after the end

The poem stops at W. And then, exactly like Psalm 34 two chapters ago, there is one more line stuck on outside the alphabet.

> Buy your people back, God. Out of every bit of it.

Now put the two extra lines side by side.

Psalm 34 ended: *God buys his people back.*

Psalm 25 ends: *Buy your people back, God.*

In Hebrew they are built on the same word. One is a statement and one is a request. One of them has been rescued already. The other has not been yet.

Both of them went all the way through the alphabet to get there. Both of them ran out of letters with something still unsaid.

BEFORE THE NEXT CHAPTER

Somebody else's name.

Everything you have written so far has been about you.

Pick a person. Somebody you are worried about would be best, but anybody will do — a friend, a brother or sister, someone at school who is having a rough time, someone you do not like very much.

Write their name down the side of the page, one letter per line.

Now write one line for each letter, asking God for them.

Not about them. **For** them.

If the name is long, you will run out of things to say halfway down and have to keep going anyway. That is normal. Psalm 25 had the same problem and left two letters out.

If a letter will not come, leave a bracket and move down the name.

And this one you do not have to show them.

6

THE ENORMOUS ONE

Psalm 119 is the longest chapter in the Bible.

One hundred and seventy-six verses. You met it in chapter 1, when the rabbis brought it up and somebody pointed out that it does the alphabet harder than anything else.

Here is how much harder.

The other poems in this book give each letter one line. This one gives each letter **eight**.

Eight lines in a row starting with A. Then eight starting with B. Then eight starting with C, and on through all twenty-two Hebrew letters, without stopping.

One letter's worth

Here is the B section. All eight of them. In Hebrew every one of these begins with the same letter.

> **B** – By what means does somebody young keep their life clean? By doing what you said.
>
> **B** – By my whole heart I am looking for you. Do not let me wander off.
>
> **B** – Buried inside me, your words are, so that I do not go wrong.

> **B** – Blessed are you. Now teach me.
>
> **B** – By my own mouth I have said out loud every rule you ever gave.
>
> **B** – Being on your road makes me happier than being rich would.
>
> **B** – Back over your instructions I go, again and again, with my eyes on your paths.
>
> **B** – Being glad about what you said is what I do. I am not going to forget it.

That is one letter.

There are twenty-one more sections exactly like it.

And nothing is missing

Go looking for the bracket. There is not one.

Psalm 145 had a hole. Psalm 34 had a hole. Psalm 37 had a hole. Psalm 25 had two holes and a repeat.

This one is perfect. Every letter, eight times each, in order, all the way through. The last poem you met that was in one piece was back in chapter 2.

What it is all about

Nearly every single verse mentions the same thing: what God has said.

And it keeps changing the word for it. His law. His word. His rules. His instructions. His promises. His ways. One thing, called by a different name almost every time.

A hundred and seventy-six verses about that.

Now the important bit

You have been writing these for five chapters. So you already know something it takes most grown-ups years to work out.

The alphabet makes you say things.

When you were stuck on the second line in chapter 2, or halfway down somebody's name in chapter 5, you did not calmly choose the perfect word. You went hunting for one that started with the right letter. The letter was in charge.

The man who wrote Psalm 119 had the same problem, one hundred and seventy-six times.

Here is a real example. Twice in this psalm, a verse begins with the Hebrew word for *hesed* — the word from chapter 1, love that has made up its mind.

Twice in a hundred and seventy-six verses. And both times, the letter he had to start with is the letter that word begins with.

So: did he put hesed there because it mattered enormously at that exact point? Or did he put it there because he needed a word beginning with that letter and had one ready?

Probably some of both. Nobody can tell from the outside.

This matters for everything else you read. People find patterns in the Bible and get very excited about them, and sometimes the pattern is there because somebody was choosing carefully, and sometimes it is there because of a rule they had set themselves.

Both happen. They are not the same thing. Ask which one you are looking at.

How anybody reads it

Most people do not sit down and read Psalm 119 in one go. Not even the ones who love it.

You read one letter. Eight lines. That is it. That is why it was built in twenty-two pieces instead of one long piece.

Tomorrow you read the next eight.

BEFORE THE NEXT CHAPTER

One letter. Eight lines.

Pick one letter. Then write eight lines with it, all about the same thing.

You can pick what the thing is. Something you are grateful for. Something you want. Somebody you are praying for. One subject, eight goes at it.

Three or four will come easily. Then it gets hard, and you will start hunting for words that begin with the right letter rather than words you meant.

When that happens, you have found what this chapter is about. It happened to the man who wrote Psalm 119, and he kept going for another hundred and sixty-eight lines.

Then read your eight back and see whether the ones you had to hunt for are worse than the ones that came easily.

Sometimes they are. Sometimes they are the best ones on the page.

7

THE ONE THAT FALLS APART

In your Bible these are two psalms with two numbers.

They are one poem.

How anybody knows

Three things.

The letters carry on. Psalm 9 runs through the alphabet and gets about halfway. Psalm 10 picks up at the next letter, exactly where Psalm 9 left off, and finishes the alphabet.

Psalm 10 has no title. Almost every psalm around it has a line at the top saying who it is by or what it is for. Psalm 10 does not. It starts mid-air.

The old Greek Bible had them as one. When the psalms were translated into Greek, a very long time ago, these two were one psalm with one number.

Somebody, at some point, split them.

The shape of it

This is what the alphabet looks like across the two psalms.

> **A** – All my heart, that is what I am thanking you with. I will tell everybody what you did.
>
> **B** – Back they turned, the ones chasing me. They fell over in front of you.
>
> **C** – Countries you have told off. Cruel people you have finished.
>
> **D** – ⟨ ⟩
>
> **E** – Enemies: gone. Even the memory of them is gone.
>
> **F** – For ever, though, God is on the throne. He set it up for judging.
>
> **G** – Give him a song. Tell everybody what he has done.
>
> **H** – Have a look at what they are doing to me. Lift me up out of this.
>
> **I** – Into the hole they dug, the nations have fallen.
>
> **J** – Judgement catches up with cruel people in the end.
>
> **K** – Keep this in mind: he does not forget poor people. Their hope does not run out.

That is Psalm 9. One letter missing, and otherwise it holds.

Now Psalm 10 starts.

> **L** – Lord, why are you standing so far away? Why are you hiding when things are bad?

And then this.

> **M** – ⟨ ⟩
>
> **N** – ⟨ ⟩
>
> **O** – ⟨ ⟩
>
> **P** – ⟨ ⟩
>
> **R** – ⟨ ⟩
>
> **S** – ⟨ ⟩

Six letters in a row. The poem keeps going – there are ten verses in there, and they are some of the hardest in the book of Psalms – but the alphabet has stopped.

Then, near the end, it comes back.

> **T** – Take action, God. Lift up your hand. Do not forget them.
>
> **U** – Up to now you have seen every bit of it. You have been looking the whole time.
>
> **V** – Very well, then: break the cruel man's arm. Hunt down every last bit of what he did.
>
> **W** – What the people being crushed are asking for, you have heard it already.

What is in the gap

The verses are still there. It is only the alphabet that has gone.

And they are about a man who hunts people who cannot fight back. He waits where they cannot see him. He crouches. They go down, and he drags them off, and nobody stops him.

And he says something, in the middle of it, that the psalm writes down.

God has forgotten. He has covered his face. He is never going to look.

Those ten verses are the part of the poem where God seems to be doing nothing at all. And they are the part where the alphabet is not working.

So was that on purpose?

Here is the honest answer. Nobody knows.

Some people think the poem got damaged. It is very old, it was copied by hand for hundreds of years, and letters can be lost.

Some people think it was written that way — that whoever wrote it let the alphabet fall over on purpose, at the exact place where everything else had fallen over too.

There is no way to settle it. You can look at it both ways and neither one can be proved.

What is certain is what the page does. It starts in order. It stops being in order where the suffering is. It picks up again at the end, and it does not go back and fix the middle.

And the question stays open

Look at the line at L again.

Why are you standing so far away? Why are you hiding when things are bad?

Nobody answers it. Not in Psalm 10, and not anywhere else in the book of Psalms. The poem asks it, goes through the worst part, and comes out at the other end still saying God is king — without ever being told why he stood back.

In chapter 1 there was a letter missing and some clever people had a theory about it.

Here there is no theory. There is a hole where six letters should be, in the part about a man who says God is not looking.

That is five psalms now with something missing, and this is the biggest hole in the book.

BEFORE THE NEXT CHAPTER

The hard one.

Everything you have written so far could be shown to somebody.

Think of something that is going badly. Not an annoyance. The real one — the thing you do not usually say out loud, about somebody who is ill, or a family that has come apart, or something that happened to you that should not have.

Write it down the alphabet, to God. Start at A and go as far as you get.

Three things about this one.

Leave out as many letters as you need to. Psalm 10 left out six in a row. You are not failing if half the page is brackets.

Do not fix the ending. You do not have to finish on something hopeful. Psalm 10 asks why God is standing far off and never gets an answer, and it is in the Bible exactly like that.

You can ask the question at L. It is already in there. Somebody got it into the Bible before you were born, and nobody has ever taken it out.

8

WHEN THE ALPHABET IS ALL YOU HAVE

This chapter is not about a psalm.

It is about a city that was destroyed, and five poems somebody wrote afterwards while standing in it.

Jerusalem was besieged and burned. The walls came down, the temple was gone, and the people who did not die were marched off to another country. There was famine first. The poems say what happened to the children during the famine, and I am not going to put those lines in here.

The book is called Lamentations. A lament is a poem for something that is lost and is not coming back.

Five poems. Four alphabets.

Chapters 1, 2, 3 and 4 are all alphabet poems. Twenty-two letters each, A to Z.

Think about that for a second.

A man is standing in the ruins of his city, and he writes in alphabetical order.

Why would anybody do that?

Nobody told him to. There is no rule saying grief has to be tidy.

The alphabet does three things for him.

It gives him somewhere to start, when there is no obvious place to start. It gives him an end he can get to. And it tells him when he is finished — not when he feels better, because he does not feel better, but when he runs out of letters.

Grief does not have a shape of its own. The alphabet has one. So he borrows it.

People tidy a room when they cannot do anything about what is actually wrong.

The middle one does it three times

Chapter 3 is the longest. Sixty-six verses.

That is because every letter gets **three** verses instead of one. Three lines starting with A, three with B, three with C, all the way through.

It is the most organised of the five, and it sits in the middle of them.

And here is what is in the middle of it

> His kindness never runs out. It is not finished. It is new every morning.
>
> You keep it up, and you keep it up. I can count on you.

That is Lamentations 3. Partway through the most organised poem in the worst book in the Bible, written by a man standing in a burnt city.

The word there is *hesed*. The one from chapter 1.

You have met it in a praise poem, in a poem asking for help, and now here. This is the hardest place it turns up, and it is the same word every time.

Two letters change places

In chapter 1 of Lamentations, the alphabet runs in the normal order.

In chapters 2, 3 and 4, two of the letters swap round.

Nobody is sure why. There are theories. None of them is settled, and I am not going to give you one and pretend it is the answer.

What you can say is this: it happens three times, and it does not happen in the first poem.

And then the fifth poem

Chapter 5 has twenty-two verses. Exactly twenty-two — the same number as all the others.

And no alphabet at all.

The letters do not run in order. They do not run in any order. The shape is still there, the right number of lines, and the thing that held them together is gone.

Four poems hold on to the alphabet. The fifth one lets go, and keeps the length, as if the habit outlasted the reason for it.

How the book ends

It does not end well.

The last lines ask God to bring them back, and then say: unless you have finished with us altogether, and you are still angry.

That is the end. There is no final verse where it comes good.

Jewish congregations reading it aloud go back and repeat the second-last verse, so that the reading does not finish on that line. They have been doing that for a very long time. It tells you they noticed, and that they did not change the text.

BEFORE THE NEXT CHAPTER

Something bigger than you.

So far you have written about yourself, and about one other person.

This time, write about something that has happened to a lot of people at once. A town after a fire. A country on the news. A school after somebody died. Something your family does not talk about any more.

Start at A and go as far as you want. Three letters, or eight, or all of them.

Then, when you have finished, do one more thing.

Write three or four more lines about the same thing, with no letters at all. No alphabet. Just say it.

Read the two back together. One of them will have been easier to write, and it may not be the one you expect. That is the difference between Lamentations 4 and Lamentations 5, and the man who wrote them did both.

9

A TO Z

Count up what you have written.

Three lines, in chapter 1. Two lines on one letter. Five lines about something that actually happened, with an extra one on the end. Seven lines over seven days. Somebody's whole name. Eight lines on one letter. And then the hard one, with as many brackets as you needed.

That is more than most adults have ever written to God in their lives.

What you have been reading

Nine psalms, and one whole book of the Bible.

Between them they do this.

One is praise with nothing left out. One is a man and the God who made him look like himself. One is a bad week told in order. One is a long argument about why cheats do well. One is asking. One is the same thing said a hundred and seventy-six times. One falls apart in the middle and never explains itself. And one is written by a man standing in the ruins of his city.

They are all built the same way. Somebody picked the alphabet and went A to Z.

The brackets were not my idea

Every exercise in this book told you that you could leave a letter out.

That permission is not mine to give. It is in the text.

Psalm 145 has no *nun*, and people have argued about it for more than fifteen hundred years. Psalm 34 has no *vav*. Psalm 37 has no *ayin*. Psalm 25 has two letters missing and one used twice. Psalms 9 and 10 have six letters gone in a row, in the part about a man who says God is not looking. Lamentations swaps two letters round three times and then drops the alphabet altogether in its last poem.

Six of the nine have holes in them — or five, if you count Psalms 9 and 10 as the one poem they really are.

The Hebrew copies were made by hand, carefully, for hundreds of years, holes and all, by people who could easily have tidied them up. They didn't.

And that is where the idea from chapter 1 runs out — the one about the alphabet being there to help people remember. If that were the main reason for it, somebody would have mended the gaps. Six of the nine were left broken. Whatever the alphabet was for, it was not mostly that. It was for saying everything.

Why anybody does this

You could be told that the psalms matter. You would have to take somebody's word for it.

Instead, look at what you have actually done.

You have said something out loud to God that you would not otherwise have said, because a letter made you reach for it. You have written a line for somebody you were worried about. You have gone back to the same complaint seven days running to find out what happens. You have written down a thing that is going badly without having to pretend it ends well.

That is what the psalms are for. Not to be admired. They were given to people to use, and you have just used them.

And the reason they can carry all that is that nothing was kept out of them. The anger is in. The questions nobody answers are in. The holes are in.

THE LAST ONE

A to Z.

The whole alphabet. One line for every letter.

What it is about: your life, as it is at the moment.

This one is different from all the others. Every exercise so far gave you one thing to write about — a bad week, a person, something unfair. This time there is no single subject. It is the lot.

So A might be your family. B might be something you are dreading on Thursday. C might be something you are grateful for and have never said so. One letter, one line, whatever that letter brings up when you look at it. They do not have to join together, and they do not have to be in any order of importance.

If a letter will not come, ask yourself what is actually going on at the moment — at home, at school, in your own head, between you and God — and see whether anything there starts with it.

Where you actually are. Not where you would like to be, and not a special occasion.

How long you have: as long as you want. A week is sensible. Chapter 4 should have taught you what hurrying costs.

The letters: English has twenty-six and Hebrew has twenty-two. This book dropped Q, X, Y and Z to get the numbers to match, and you can do the same. Or keep them and find out how hard X is.

The rules, one last time:

1. Say each line out loud before you write it. This has been a song all the way through.
2. It does not have to be good.
3. Brackets wherever you need them.
4. It does not have to end well.

And then — say it three times.

The book is named after an old instruction. Say this psalm three times every day. People have been doing it for a very long time, and that is where we started in chapter 1.

Here is a smaller version of it, for the thing you have just written.

Say it out loud the day you finish it.

Say it again a week later.

Say it again a month after that.

Then look at what has changed. Some of the lines will have stopped being true. One or two will have become true in a way they were not when you wrote them. The brackets may have filled in, and you may need new ones.

That is what the people saying Psalm 145 three times a day have always known. You do not say it again because you have forgotten it. You say it again because you are different, and it is the same.

One more thing

There are a hundred and fifty psalms.

You have read nine.

The other hundred and forty-one are not alphabet poems, which means they are free to be any shape they like, and they are. One is only two verses long. Some are songs for walking. One is for somebody who cannot sleep. There are several that are angrier than anything in this book.

They are all still there. Nobody has tidied those either.

FOR YOUNGER READERS

Who Would Have Thought – *Psalm 19*

A girl, a long week at home, and a verse caught by accident. Jess wasn't looking for Psalm 19, but six old lines found her – somewhere between the medicine tablets, her gran's folded hands and a phone bright in the dark. There is also an illustrated edition, hand-lettered, with soft line drawings and the light always doing something. Made to be read aloud, or held quietly.

The Songs for Every Day – *seven psalms, one for each day of the week*

The songs the singers sang in the temple, a different one for every day. Sunday says whose world this is. Tuesday asks who gets left out at your school. Wednesday is for when things are unfair and nobody seems to be doing anything about it. Saturday puts grass and a cedar tree side by side. Each day has something to wonder about and a prayer you can say. *The Tamid Psalms* is the same seven for an adult reading alongside.

FOR TEENAGERS

Therefore – *Romans 12*

Seven days through one chapter. For eleven chapters Paul explains what God has done, and then chapter twelve begins with *therefore*. Sunday is the one day that is not about you. Thursday uses the same word about the people who hunt you: bless them. A page to write or draw on each day, and a note for the adult reading with you.

The Man Who Opened His Hand — *Job*

The book of Job told as a story, for anyone who wants to know why it is in there at all — and the secret kept in a single verse near the end.

This book did not begin with artificial intelligence. It began with years of ministry, reading, prayer, suffering, and conversation.

During its development, AI became a conversation partner. It challenged assumptions, tested arguments, suggested structures, and helped refine expression. Many of the words here emerged through that dialogue.

The experiences, convictions, interpretations, and conclusions remain my own.